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California considers ban on Flamin' Hot Cheetos and other popular snacks in public schools; here's why

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India, March 17 -- California lawmakers recently introduced a bill to ban Flamin' Hot Cheetos, Doritos, and Mountain Dew in public schools, alleging adverse health effects on students. The measure seeks to get rid of child-focused foods that contain artificial ingredients such as red 40, blue 1, and titanium dioxide.

Cheetos and Doritos contain colorings red 40, yellow 5, and yellow 6, which are likely to be banned if the bill is approved. Cereals such as Fruity Pebbles and Froot Loops are made up using these yellow and red dyes, as well as blue 1.

According to the Center for Science in the Public Interest, some soups and cheese brands contain titanium dioxide.

"The science is complicated but the purpose of the bill is not. This is about protecting our students from chemicals that have been proven to harm children and interfere with their ability to learn," stated Jesse Gabriel, the author of the bill and state Assembly member, at a press conference.

Taking to X (formerly Twitter), Gabriel announced the bill and said these chemicals are "linked to serious health concerns including DNA damage, cancer, hyperactivity, and neurobehavioral issues from food served to students."

Under current California legislation, the state's education department must follow nutritional criteria while providing meals on campus. All kids in the state, from kindergarten to 12th grade, are eligible for free lunch and breakfast.

According to the current standards, items served to students must contain fruits, vegetables, dairy, protein, or whole grains. The guidelines also establish requirements for calories, carbohydrates, and fats in certain items.

Gabriel stated that the matter was "personal to him" because he and his children are battling with attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (ADHS).

However, the schools would be allowed to sell foods containing synthetic dyes at off-campus events or half-an-hour after the conclusion of the school day .

In 2012, the National Institutes of Health (NIH) conducted a study and found that red 3 causes cancer in animals, and that red 40, yellow 5, and yellow 6 are tainted with carcinogens such as benzidine, which may increase the risk of developing cancer.

The NIH suggested removing these dyes as they do not improve the nutritional value of foods. The FDA also does not permit the use of a color additive that has been known to cause cancer in humans or animals.

The National Confectioners Association, which represents confectionery firms such as Mars, Haribo, and Hershey, criticised the bill as part of a "sensationalistic agenda that is not based on facts and science."

"These activists are dismantling our national food safety system state by state in an emotionally-driven campaign that lacks scientific backing," the NCA said in a statement.

The bill is anticipated to be debated by the Assembly Education Committee in the coming weeks.

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